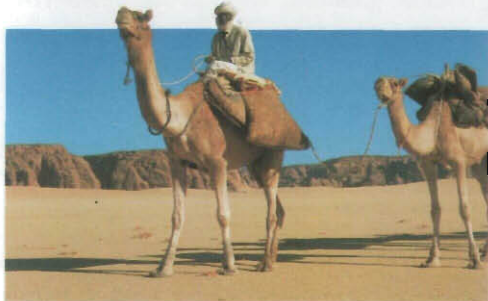


Chad

 The land-locked republic of Chad is one of the world's poorest countries. Nearly half of the land is desert or lies in the Sahel, where rainfall is erratic. More than half of the people work on farmland near the Chari river in the south, but lack of food is still a problem. Chad has some valuable mineral deposits, but they are unexploited.



Muslim nomads

More than 100,000 nomadic Muslims live in the desert and northern Sahel regions of Chad. They include the Kanimbo people, who are related to the Arabs and Berbers of North Africa. Every day, Kanimbo women must walk long distances in the heat to fetch water for their families.

Camels

One of the only ways to cross the vast Sahara Desert is by camel. Camels are used as pack animals to transport forest products and minerals from Lake Chad, as well as for farming, pumping water, and carrying people. Herders value their milk, meat, and hides.

Dried gourds used as bowls for making butter.



Fulani

Throughout Africa a nomadic group called the Fulani herd cattle and roam wherever there is grazing land. They drink the cows' milk and use it to make butter and cheese. Bottle-shaped gourds, a type of fruit, are dried and decorated for use as water carriers and bowls.

CHAD FACTS

CAPITAL CITY N'Djamena

AREA 1,259,200 sq km
(486,177 sq miles)

POPULATION 7,700,000

MAIN LANGUAGES French, Arabic, Sara

MAJOR RELIGIONS Muslim, Christian, traditional beliefs

CURRENCY CFA franc

Cameroon

 On Africa's west coast, Cameroon was once a colony divided between the French and the British. The two parts gained independence and became a united country in 1961. Despite initial troubles, Cameroon now has one of the most successful economies in Africa, exporting oil, bauxite, and a range of natural products, including cocoa, coffee, and rubber. The country has a diverse culture with more than 230 ethnic groups.



Timber

Like many other African countries, Cameroon sells hardwood logs, including mahogany, ebony, and teak from its rainforests to earn foreign currency. Although the trade represents one tenth of the country's total exports, it poses a serious threat to the future of the forests.

Football

One of Cameroon's leading amateur sports, football is widely enjoyed and people play it whenever they have time. Games draw large crowds of spectators. Cameroon's national football team was acclaimed as one of the best in Africa, after displaying its skills in the 1990 World Cup.



CAMEROON FACTS

CAPITAL CITY Yaoundé

AREA 465,400 sq km (179,691 sq miles)

POPULATION 15,100,000

MAIN LANGUAGES French, English, Fang, Duala, Fulani

MAJOR RELIGIONS Traditional beliefs, Christian, Muslim

CURRENCY CFA franc



Music

Makossa is a popular style of African folk music that originated in Cameroon. It is played on traditional instruments, including this one, known as a *mvet*. It is made using a wooden stick, horseshair strings, and hollowed-out gourds. *Mvet* players are specially trained and highly regarded in the community.

Dried gourds amplify sounds made by strings.

Several strings are stretched along the stick and plucked to make a range of sounds.

Central African Republic

 Lying in the very heart of Africa, the Central African Republic, or CAR, has a complicated history. Drought and 13 years of repressive government have made the CAR one of the poorest nations in the world. Only two per cent of the people live in the semi-arid north, and the majority are clustered in villages in the southern rainforests.



Bantu woman

Cotton

Coffee and cotton together form about 13 per cent of the country's exports. Grown on large plantations, all parts of the cotton plant are used. The fibre, known as a boll, is spun into yarn to make fabric. The seed's oil forms the base of many foods, whilst the plant's stalks and leaves are ploughed back into the soil to fertilize it.



CENTRAL AFRICAN REPUBLIC FACTS

CAPITAL CITY Bangui

AREA 622,980 sq km (240,530 sq miles)

POPULATION 3,600,000

MAIN LANGUAGES French, Sango, Zande, Banda, Sara, Arabic

MAJOR RELIGIONS Traditional beliefs, Christian, Muslim

CURRENCY CFA franc

After drying in the sun, cotton bolls are sorted by hand.

Millet



Cassava



People

Seven major Bantu language groups and many smaller ones make up the population of the CAR. Several thousand hunter-gatherers live in the rainforests in harmony with nature. They survive by eating forest fruits and build their homes from banana leaves.

Food

The people of the CAR grow nearly all their own food by subsistence farming. Root crops, such as cassava, yams, and vegetables, are cultivated alongside grains including millet, maize, and sorghum. Fish from the CAR's rivers, including the Chari and Ubangi, is a vital source of protein.